Our dressing room was silent again. In black and white, South Africa had hosted three major ICC tournaments on our own soil – the ICC Cricket World Cup in 2003, the World Twenty20 in 2007 and the ICC Champions Trophy in 2009 – and we had not reached a single semifinal.

Andrew Strauss led his England team back to South Africa for a full tour at the end of the year, and we remained frustratingly inconsistent. We lost the first T20 international, but won the next. We lost the first ODI, but won the next on a truly glorious day at Newlands when I managed to score 121 in a winning total of 354. We travelled to play the decider in Port Elizabeth and were dismissed for only 114. The series was lost.

Four Tests and more frustration followed. We should have won the first Test in Centurion, but they held out for the draw on the last day, finishing with nine wickets down. We then collapsed on the fourth afternoon of the second Test in Durban, routed by Graeme Swann, and lost ...

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We created another winning position in the third Test at Newlands but again failed to deliver a knockout blow; for the second time in the series, England were nine wickets down at the end and escaped with a draw.

Finally, we completed the task in the fourth Test in Johannesburg when Graeme scored yet another outstanding century. The victory meant the series was drawn, but we knew we really should have won.

After the triumphs of 2008, the disappointments of 2009 had left a sense of annoyance and agitation within the squad. There seemed to be more than enough ability and experience in our dressing room for the team to dominate all formats of the game, and yet, now and then, for no apparent reason, we underperformed and let ourselves down.

It was certainly not Mickey Arthur's fault, but he nonetheless stepped down as coach before our tour to India, to be replaced by Corrie van